

'Ammonites, the Moabites, the Egyptians, and the Emorites;

2 For they have taken of their daughters for themselves and for their sons; and the holy seed have mingled themselves with the nations of these lands; and the hand of the princes and rulers hath been the first in this trespass.

3 And when I heard this thing, I rent my garment and my mantle, and I plucked out some of the hair of my head and of my beard, and sat down astounded.

4 And then assembled themselves unto me every one that trembled at the words of the God of Israel, because of the trespass of the exiles: and I sat astounded until the evening sacrifice.

5 And at the evening sacrifice I rose up from my fasting, and while rending^a my garment and my mantle, I knelt down upon my knees, and spread out my hands unto the LORD my God.

6 And I said, O my God, I am ashamed and confounded to lift up my face unto thee, my God! for our iniquities are increased above our head, and our guiltiness is grown up as far as the heavens.

7 From the days of our fathers have we been in a great guiltiness even until this day; and through our iniquities have we been delivered, we, our kings, and our priests, into the hand of the kings of the lands, to the sword, to captivity, and to a spoil, and to the shame of face, as it is this day.

8 And now for a little moment hath grace been extended from the LORD our God, to preserve us a remnant to escape, and to give us a stake^b in his holy place, that our God might enlighten our eyes, and give us a little reviving in our bondage.

9 For we are bondmen: yet in our bondage hath our God not forsaken us, but hath extended unto us kindness before the kings of Persia, to give us a reviving, to exalt the house of our God, and to erect again its ruins, and to give us a fence^c in Judah and in Jerusalem.

10 And now what shall we say, O our

God, after this? for we have forsaken thy commandments,

11 Which thou hast commanded through means of thy servants the prophets, saying, The land, unto which ye go to take possession thereof, is a land defiled through the defilement of the nations of the lands, through their abominations, with which they have filled it from one end to another through their uncleanness.

12 And now your daughters shall ye not give unto their sons, and their daughters shall ye not take for your sons, and ye shall not seek their peace and their welfare unto eternity: in order that ye may be strong, and eat the best of the land, and leave it for an inheritance to your children unto eternity.

13 And after all that is come over us for our evil deeds, and for our great guiltiness, seeing that thou our God hast spared us (punishing us) less than our iniquities (deserved), and hast given us such deliverance as this:

14 Should we again make void thy commandments, and make marriage with these people of abominations? wouldst thou not be angry with us even to make an end of us, so that there would not be any remnant or escape?

15 ¶ O LORD, God of Israel, thou art righteous; for we have been left a remnant that hath escaped, as it is this day: behold, we are before thee in our guiltinesses; for there is no standing^d before thee because of this.

CHAPTER X.

1 ¶ Now when 'Ezra prayed, and when he made his confession, weeping and casting himself down before the house of God, there gathered themselves unto him out of Israel a very large assembly of men and women and children; for the people wept exceedingly much.

2 ¶ Thereupon commenced Shechanyah the son of Jechiel, of the sons of 'Elam, and said unto 'Ezra, We have indeed trespassed against our God, and have brought home strange wives of the nations of the land: yet

^a First, "and with my rent garment and mantle," &c.

^b Lat. "nail," i. e. the nail or stake by which the ends of a tent are fastened to the ground, metaphoric for something not easily removed.

^c As round a sheepfold; i. e. protection.

^d Meaning, it is sure that God's mercy permitted the people to escape total destruction; but this new transgression would cause that the LORD would sweep off those who, notwithstanding the merciful chastisement, could so soon forget again their God.